Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Resources in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

This study will use a qualitative methodology. Qualitative research explores a central phenomenon by collecting the words of a small number of participants in their natural settings and analyzing those words inductively, with the researcher as the primary instrument of data collection and analysis (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Grounded in constructivism, it seeks to understand how people make meaning of their social realities, whereas quantitative research tests hypotheses through predetermined variables and may miss unanticipated experiences (Mwita, 2022).

A qualitative methodology fits the purpose of this study, which is to explore how newcomer families at one Toronto child care centre describe learning about, and using or not using, family support resources that the centre offers or refers. The central research question asks how newcomer families describe their experiences of accessing and using these resources. The sub-questions ask (1) what helps or limits families in learning about, applying for, and deciding whether to use resources, and (2) how families describe their opportunities to share needs with the centre and the centre's response. Because these questions concern meaning and process, and the barriers families face cannot be listed in advance as survey items, the study needs the in-depth information that qualitative research provides (Mwita, 2022).

The literature review supports this choice. Survey research found that most parents had heard of the Canada-wide Early Learning and Child Care (CWELCC) system but held incorrect or limited information about it (Burns et al., 2025). However, a survey cannot explain how such gaps shape a family's decisions. Qualitative research, in contrast, revealed details that matter for practice, such as families relying on a provider's handwritten registration instructions (Fakhari et al., 2023). Families' own accounts can also fill the gap in Toronto-specific evidence that the review identified. Since qualitative findings cannot be generalized (Mwita, 2022), the study seeks in-depth understanding of one centre.

In qualitative work, the researcher is the main tool for gathering and making sense of data. For this reason, the researcher's position must be stated (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The researcher is a Registered Early Childhood Educator who completed an internship at the study site. That insider view helps, but it can also hide bias. The researcher may assume that families already understand how subsidies and referrals work. To keep this in check, the researcher will keep a reflexive journal throughout the study. Writing these assumptions down makes them easier to notice and helps manage bias (Mwita, 2022).

Research Design

The specific design for this study is qualitative description. Sandelowski introduced this approach as a way to give a full summary of events in the everyday words of the people who lived them (Sandelowski, 2000, as cited in Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). The design stays close to the data. Its interpretation is low-inference, so researchers can more easily agree on what participants actually said. It also studies events as they happen, with no variables or theory chosen in advance (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). Phenomenology looks for the essence of an experience. Grounded theory builds new theory, and ethnography gives a detailed account of a culture. Qualitative description sets none of these goals (Villamin et al., 2025).

There are three reasons this design fits the study. First, the research question should guide the choice of design (Villamin et al., 2025). Here, the sub-questions ask families who helped them, which steps were confusing, and how the centre responded. Plain description can answer these questions without building theory. Second, qualitative description is useful when researchers need information directly from the people affected and when resources are limited (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024), as in a single-centre student study. Third, findings close to participants' words can inform practice (Villamin et al., 2025), in this case for the educators who explain and refer resources. Ilumin (2023) applied the same design to immigrant families' child care experiences in Edmonton.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will be four newcomer parents or primary caregivers. In this study, a newcomer family is an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant must (a) be aged 18 or older, (b) have arrived in Canada within the past five years, in any immigration category, (c) have a child enrolled at Parkdale Child Care Centre, (d) have been offered or referred at least one resource by the centre in the past 12 months, such as the City of Toronto child care fee subsidy, EarlyON, or settlement services, whether or not it was used, and (e) be able to participate in English or Mandarin, or with an interpreter.

The study will include families who used a resource and families who did not, because knowing about a resource does not mean using it. Families from the researcher's placement room and families of centre staff will be left out. This lowers the risk of a power imbalance (Villamin et al., 2025). The study will also not ask about immigration status. Fee subsidy applications require tax documents, and undocumented families often cannot provide them (Schmidt, 2026). Asking about status could therefore discourage some families from taking part.

Recruitment Setting

Recruitment will take place at Parkdale Child Care Centre. It is a licensed centre in the Parkdale neighbourhood of west Toronto, and it is also where the researcher completed an internship. There, the researcher saw a parent mistake the City's subsidy waitlist for the centre's enrollment waitlist, an observation that prompted this study.

This centre suits the study for three reasons. Staff there actually offer resources and make referrals. Because all participants come from one site, they share a context, and their stories are easier to compare. The third reason comes from city policy. Toronto's service plan names child care settings as access points and lists tax-filing rules as a barrier to fee subsidy (Toronto

Children's Services, 2025). A study in one centre can show how these policies affect families on the ground.

Recruitment Methods

Families will be invited by the centre director rather than by the researcher. Recruitment will follow six steps:

1. The researcher will first seek approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). The director will also be asked for a letter of support.
2. The researcher will create a one-page flyer and a letter of information in plain English. Both will be translated into Mandarin and other languages often spoken at the centre. The materials will explain the purpose of the study and the time needed, which is 45 to 60 minutes. They will also state that taking part is voluntary, mention the $25 gift card, and give contact details.
3. The director will share the invitation in the parent newsletter, on the notice board, and in family cubbies. Staff will not approach any family one on one. Following Hardware et al. (2026), recruitment will be handled by someone other than the lead researcher. This helps avoid a conflict of interest.
4. Parents who are interested will contact the researcher directly by email, phone, or text. This way, the centre will not know who takes part. A short 10-minute call will then confirm eligibility.
5. Eligible parents will receive the letter and consent form in the language they prefer. They will have at least 48 hours to decide.
6. If fewer than four parents sign up within three weeks, the director will send one reminder. After that, participants may refer other eligible families (Hardware et al., 2026).

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. The study will use criterion sampling, which is a type of purposive sampling. Where possible, it will also aim for maximum variation. Snowball sampling will serve as a backup. These are the strategies used most often in qualitative descriptive studies (Villamin et al., 2025).

Participant Selection. The researcher will screen respondents in order of contact. When more than four parents qualify, the researcher will choose those who differ the most. The main points of difference are resource use, type of resource, time in Canada, and home language. Only one adult from each family will take part. Other eligible parents will be placed on a waitlist.

Sample Size. The study will include four participants, as required for individual submissions.

Rationale. Criterion sampling makes sure that every participant can speak to the research questions. Maximum variation means that even a small sample can include families who used resources and families who did not. That mix responds to the gap found in the literature review. Saturation often requires 9 to 17 interviews (Hennink & Kaiser, 2022), so four interviews may not reach it. The study accepts this limit and does not try to generalize. Its aim is a detailed description that can guide practice at the centre.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through one-on-one, semi-structured interviews. Focus groups would not suit this study. Income and subsidy eligibility are sensitive topics, and families at the same centre may know one another (Villamin et al., 2025). Each interview will be held in the participant's preferred language so that meaning is not lost (Ilumin, 2023). The researcher is bilingual and will interview Mandarin speakers directly. For other languages, a confidential interpreter will help. Each participant will go through four steps:

1. **Informed consent (15 minutes).** The researcher will explain several points. Taking part is voluntary, and participants can withdraw until analysis begins. Their child's

care will not be affected, and the centre will not know who took part. The interview will be recorded, and each participant will be reported under a pseudonym. Consent can be signed or given verbally. It will be confirmed again at the member check (Villamin et al., 2025).

2. **Background form (5 minutes).** This short form asks about years in Canada, children's ages, home language, and resources used. It does not ask about immigration status or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** Families can choose to meet at the centre, on Zoom, or by phone. Those who join online may turn off their camera and use a pseudonym, as in Hardware et al. (2026). The first four questions relate to sub-question 1. They cover how the family learned about the resource, how they understood eligibility, which steps were unclear, and what help they received. The fifth question asks why the family did or did not use the resource. The sixth relates to sub-question 2 and asks how the family shared needs with the centre and how the centre responded. A pilot interview with one non-participant will test the wording, translation, and length. At the end, the participant will receive a $25 gift card and a list of supports such as EarlyON and 211 Toronto.
4. **Transcription and member check (two weeks).** The interview will be transcribed within one week, and a bilingual reviewer will check translations using forward and backward translation (Ilumin, 2023). A two-page summary in the participant's language will be sent for optional feedback, after which participation ends.

All data will be pseudonymized, encrypted, and stored separately from consent forms. Because the sample is small, reports will describe the centre only as a centre in west Toronto, will not combine identifiers such as country of origin and language, and will alter identifying quotations or use them only with consent (Villamin et al., 2025).

Data will be analyzed using the six phases of reflexive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2022). The process moves from getting familiar with the data and coding in families'

own words to defining themes linked to the sub-questions. Case summaries and a cross-case matrix will help compare families who used resources with those who did not. Because themes in this approach are interpretive, member checks will not be used to verify codes. Participants will instead check whether the summaries reflect what they meant. The reflexive journal and an audit trail will record each analytic decision.

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Phase	Timeframe	Main tasks
1. Research proposal	Sept. to Dec. 2026	Complete and revise the proposal
2. Ethics approval	Jan. to Feb. 2027	Submit application, materials, and translations
3. Recruitment	Feb. to Mar. 2027	Distribute invitations, screen, and obtain consent
4. Data collection	Mar. to Apr. 2027	Pilot, four interviews, transcription, and member checks
5. Data analysis	Apr. to May 2027	Reflexive thematic analysis and case matrix
6. Reporting	May to June 2027	Final report, class presentation, and summary to centre

The researcher will revise the proposal in Phase 1 based on feedback. Ethics review gets six weeks in Phase 2. Recruitment in Phase 3 leaves room for a reminder and, if needed, snowball sampling. During Phase 4, interviews are spaced out so that transcription and member checks can keep pace. Analysis takes four to six weeks in Phase 5, and the findings will be shared in class and with the centre in Phase 6.

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